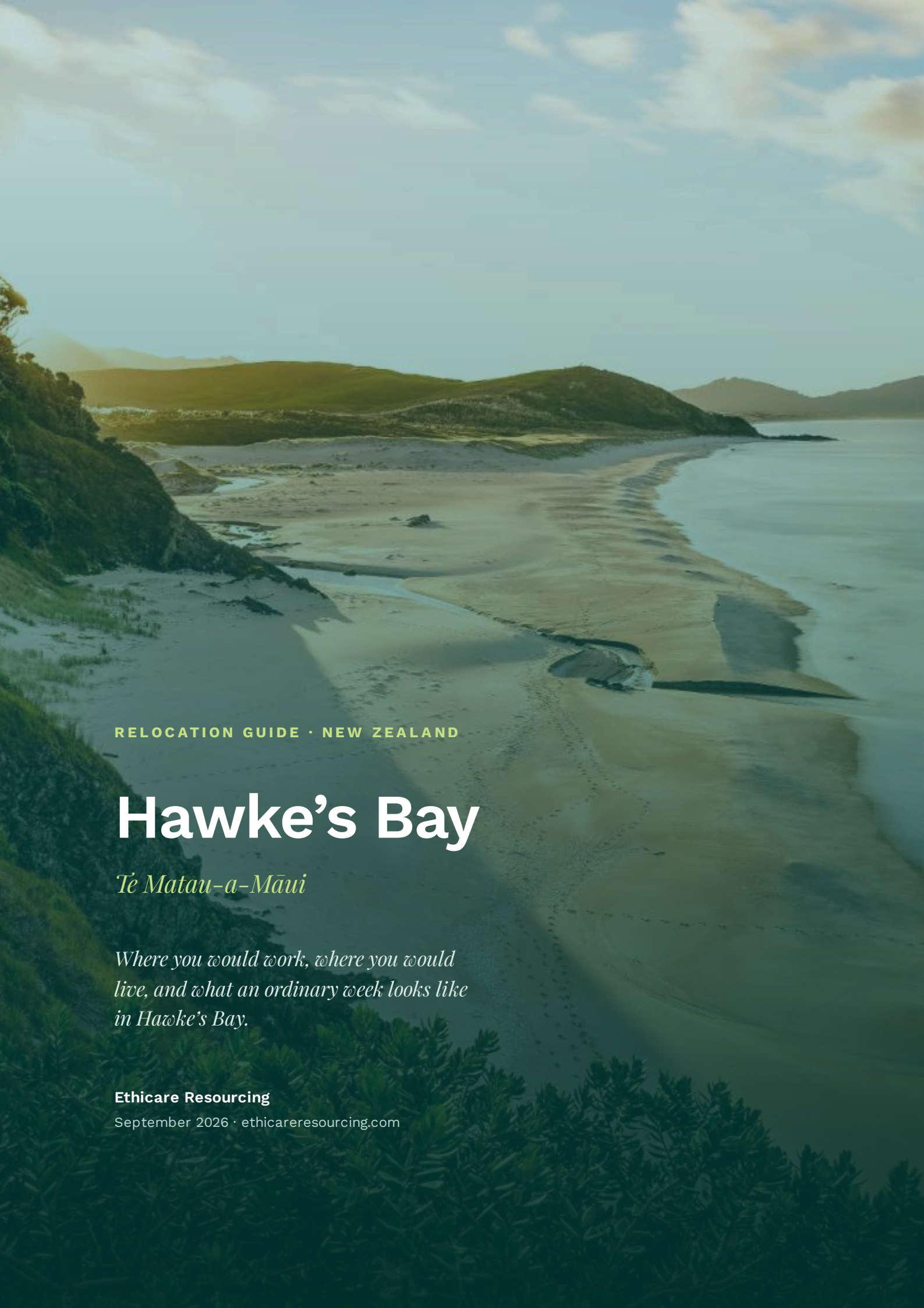




RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Hawke's Bay

Tē Matau-a-Māui

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Hawke's Bay.

Ethicare Resourcing

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Nau mai ki Tē Matau-a-Māui

Welcome to Hawke's Bay

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Hawke's Bay turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

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This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

TE MATAU-A-MĀUI

Welcome to Hawke's Bay

Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Matau-a-Māui. Hawke's Bay is a wide, sunlit crescent of coast on the east of the North Island — two cities twenty minutes apart, a fertile plain between them, hill country behind, and one of the great food and wine regions of the southern hemisphere.

~180,000

People across the region, from Wairoa in the north to Central Hawke's Bay in the south.

~67,000 / ~55,000

Napier and Hastings — twin cities twenty minutes apart, each with its own character and its own loyalties.

2,200+ HRS

Of sunshine a year. Hawke's Bay competes with Nelson and the Bay of Plenty for sunniest region in the country most years.

The sunny east coast

Hawke's Bay is shaped like a fish hook, which is what its Māori name describes. Napier sits on the northern arm of the bay, rebuilt in Art Deco after the 1931 earthquake and now holding one of the finest concentrations of that architecture anywhere in the world. Hastings lies twenty minutes inland across the Heretaunga plains, larger in its district, and home to the region's base hospital.

Between and around them: apple and pear orchards, some of New Zealand's most celebrated vineyards, and the flat, cyclable Heretaunga plain. Beyond, the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges rise inland, the coast runs south past Te Mata Peak to Cape Kidnappers, and north the road climbs towards Wairoa and the East Cape.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Hawke's Bay specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Hawke's Bay](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Where clinicians live](#), because the Napier-or-Hastings question is the first real decision you'll make here.



02

THE CASE FOR HAWKE'S BAY

Why Hawke's Bay

Hawke's Bay makes one of the strongest overall cases in this collection, and it is the region we find ourselves comparing most often to the Bay of Plenty. On most measures that a clinician actually feels, it wins.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY

Ten to twenty-five minutes to the hospital depending which city you live in. Flat roads, easy parking, and a genuine option to cycle year-round.

AFTER WORK

Long light evenings for most of the year. Marine Parade in Napier, Te Mata Peak for the view, or a swim. The sea is comfortable from December to April.

SATURDAY

The Hastings farmers' market, then a cellar door or a beach. This is the region's great weekend rhythm, and it does not get old.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, radiographer, physiotherapist or sonographer on a given step earns the same in Hastings as in Auckland or Tauranga. What changes is what the money buys.

Here it buys a good deal. Housing costs meaningfully less than in Tauranga or Auckland for a comparable coastal, sunny lifestyle — not as little as Palmerston North or Southland, but enough that buying a family home on a clinical salary is realistic rather than aspirational. Commutes are twenty minutes. Parking is easy. The food and wine are extraordinary and, being local, are cheaper than they should be.

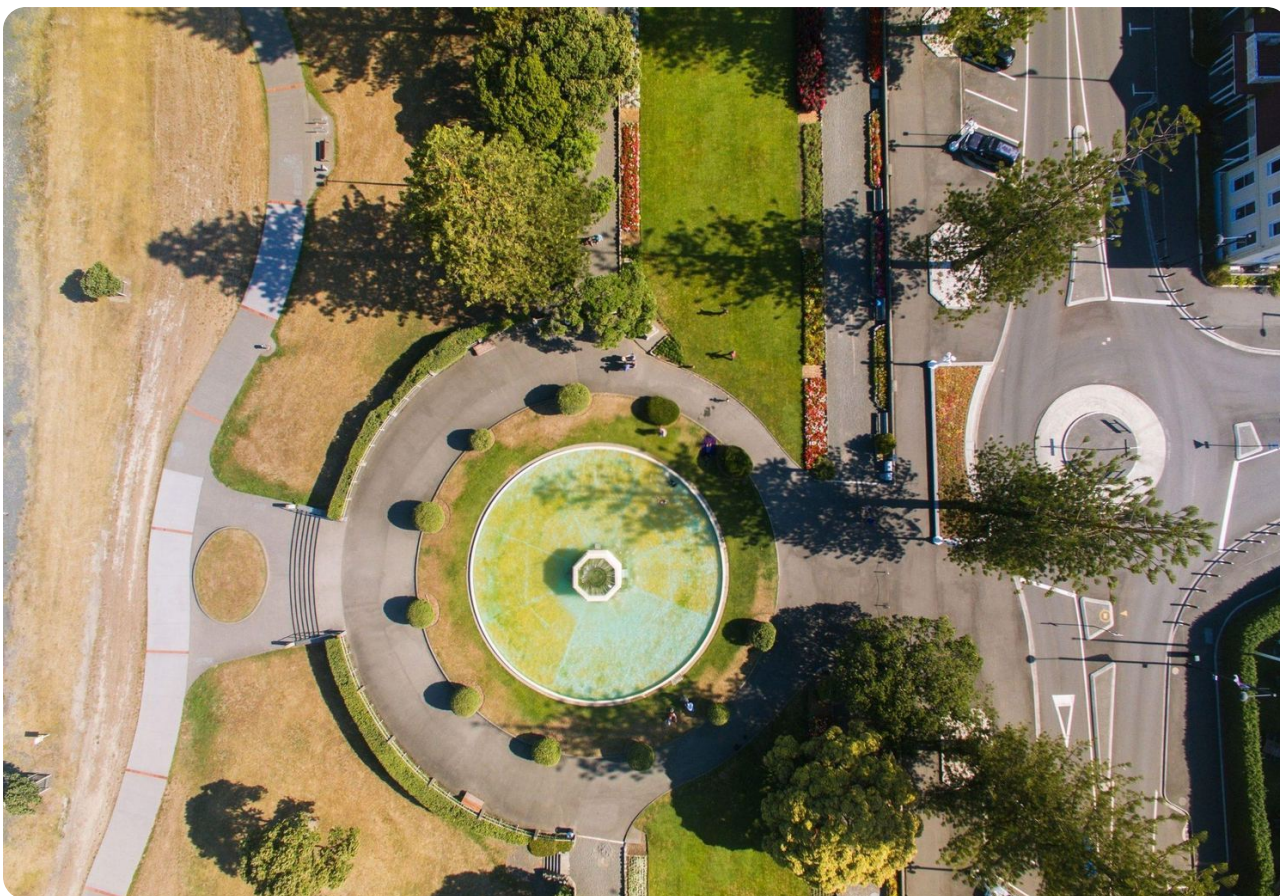
The six things people ask us

Yes. Hawke's Bay is a base hospital serving a whole region of a hundred and eighty thousand people, including a large rural catchment north to Wairoa and south to Central Hawke's Bay. Acute medicine and surgery, emergency, maternity, paediatrics, intensive care, imaging and a broad outpatient service. It is not a tertiary centre, so the most complex work goes to Wellington — [Healthcare here](#) is specific about what stays and what travels.

The first real question here, and there is no wrong answer. Napier for the coast, the Art Deco streets and a slightly more polished feel; Hastings for the hospital on your doorstep, more space for your money and a more mixed, working city. Havelock North sits between them and takes the premium for it. [Where clinicians live](#) compares them properly.

Where we'd point you instead

Hawke's Bay suits clinicians who want the good-life move to still feel professional — a proper base hospital, then vineyards and coastline for everything after five. It's the region we hear the fewest regrets about.



03

SUN, PLAIN AND HILL COUNTRY

Hawke's Bay at a glance

A wide bay open to the Pacific, a fertile alluvial plain behind it, and ranges beyond that which strip the westerly of its rain. That geography gives Hawke's Bay its sunshine, its wine and its drought — and, occasionally, its floods.

NAPIER ↔ HASTINGS

20 minutes across the plain. The single most-driven route in the region.

→ HAVELOCK NORTH

10 minutes from Hastings, 25 from Napier, at the foot of Te Mata Peak.

→ THE BEACHES

20 to 40 minutes to Waimarama, Ocean Beach or Waipatiki.

The shape of the region

Napier sits at the northern end of the bay on a low hill that was an island until the 1931 earthquake lifted the seabed around it. South across the flat **Heretaunga plain** lies Hastings, with Havelock North tucked beneath Te Mata Peak between them. The plain is the productive heart: orchards, vineyards and market gardens on some of the best soil in the country.

West, the land rises through hill-country sheep and cattle stations to the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges – the barrier that makes this coast dry. North, the road climbs past the Esk Valley towards Wairoa and eventually the East Cape. South, the coast runs past Cape Kidnappers and its gannet colony into Central Hawke's Bay, the small towns of Waipawa and Waipukurau, and eventually the Wairarapa.

The four seasons

Indicative daytime highs on the plain. Inland and in the hill country, winters are colder and frosts are routine.

This is the closest the North Island comes to a Mediterranean climate. Somewhere above 2,200 sunshine hours a year, hot dry summers, and mild winters on the coast. It is why the wine ripens the way it does, and why the fruit is what it is. If you have come from northern Europe, the number of usable outdoor days here will genuinely change your year.

Words you'll hear

A sunny, dry, fertile east-coast region with two cities twenty minutes apart and hill country behind. The climate is the reason people come; drought and exposure to tropical weather are the honest costs. The first real decision is Napier or Hastings – **Where clinicians live** is next.

Healthcare in Hawke's Bay

Hawke's Bay is a base hospital region with a genuinely wide catchment, a substantial equity agenda, and a rural reach that runs from the East Cape road to the Wairarapa border. For most professions it offers real breadth without demanding that you live somewhere remote.

REAL BREADTH

A base hospital with no competing centre nearby means you see what the region produces. Wide scope, more decisions carried by you, and referral options further away.

EQUITY AT THE CENTRE

Around a quarter of Hawke's Bay people identify as Māori, and parts of the region carry significant deprivation and unmet need. Much of the most meaningful work here is in closing that gap.

A LARGE RURAL CATCHMENT

Wairoa to the north and Central Hawke's Bay to the south. Outreach, travel and access work are part of many roles.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. The base hospital sits in **Hastings** — a point worth absorbing early, because Napier is the better-known city and the two are twenty minutes apart. It carries acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, oncology day services, imaging and a broad outpatient and day-procedure programme for the whole region.

Around it: community and outpatient services across both cities, primary care, iwi and Māori health providers, aged residential care, and rural services reaching north to Wairoa and south into Central Hawke's Bay. Distance is a live factor in the rural districts, and it became a much more prominent one after Cyclone Gabrielle.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the heartland of Ngāti Kahungunu, the third-largest iwi in the country, and te ao Māori is woven through health delivery here rather than added to it. Iwi and Māori health providers are a substantial part of the care landscape, particularly in Wairoa, Flaxmere and the rural districts.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau in the room and involved in decisions, and services designed around that. You are not expected to arrive fluent — you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured — ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system — lives in [How the health system works](#).



05

NAPIER OR HASTINGS

Where clinicians live

The first real decision in Hawke's Bay is which city. The base hospital is in Hastings, the best-known coastline is in Napier, and they are twenty minutes apart — so plenty of people work in one and live in the other quite happily.

NAPIER HILL & BLUFF HILL

The old town on the hill that was once an island, with character houses, views over the bay and steep streets. Sought-after and priced accordingly.

AHURIRI

The redeveloped waterfront and marina quarter — apartments, restaurants and a real sense of place. Popular with couples and downsizers.

TARADALE & GREENMEADOWS

Established, leafy, family-focused suburbs on the Napier side of the plain, with good schools and a shorter run to the Hastings hospital than central Napier.

Further out

Most clinicians we move here rent for six to twelve months first, which is the right call: it lets you learn which city you actually belong in before committing. How renting works — the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards — is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).



06

A COASTAL LIFESTYLE FOR LESS

Cost of living

Hawke's Bay sits in the useful middle of this collection.

HAVELOCK NORTH

The region's premium address, on schooling reputation and village feel. Expect to pay the top of the local range and to compete for anything good.

NAPIER HILL, BLUFF HILL & AHURIRI

Character, views and waterfront. Priced for it, and limited stock.

TARADALE, GREENMEADOWS & MAREWA

The sensible middle. Good schools, established streets, reasonable prices and a short run to Hastings.

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Hawke's Bay against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Where it sits

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Auckland or Tauranga, into a market that costs noticeably less than either. Prices here rose substantially over the last decade, as they did everywhere, and the region is no longer the bargain it once was — but the gap to Tauranga is real and it is the comparison worth making.

Concretely: a family home with a garden in a good school zone, within twenty-five minutes of the hospital, is a realistic purchase on a clinical salary here. In Tauranga the same thing is hard on two incomes. That is the case for Hawke's Bay in one sentence.

Renting, by area

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is just over half the month — more than Palmerston North, materially less than the Bay of Plenty.

Power is among the lowest lines of any region in this collection — a warm, dry climate showing up in a bill rather than a brochure. The car is the trade for it.



07 FLAT, SHORT AND EASY Getting around

The Heretaunga plain is flat, the two cities are twenty minutes apart, and there is almost no congestion worth the name. Getting around inside Hawke's Bay is easy. Getting to Wellington is the part to think about.

THE REGIONAL NETWORK

goBay services link Napier, Hastings, Havelock North and Taradale, with school and city routes. Cheap and useful on the main corridors.

ITS LIMITS

Frequency outside the main routes is modest and evening service is thin. It will not cover a clinical roster.

DO YOU NEED A CAR?

Yes, though possibly only one per household if you cycle. The region assumes a vehicle for the beaches, the hill country and the rural districts.

The twin-city commute

Napier to Hastings is about twenty minutes on the expressway across the plain, and that single route is the spine of the region. Plenty of clinicians live in one city and work in the other; plenty more live in Havelock North or Taradale, which sit between them and shorten it either way.

There is mild thickening at the school run and at either end of the day, and roadworks on the expressway from time to time. That is the whole traffic story. Parking at the hospital and in both city centres is straightforward and cheap or free.

Cycling — one of the best in the country

The **Hawke's Bay Trails** are a Great Ride: roughly two hundred kilometres of linked, sealed, almost entirely flat path across the plain, along the rivers and around the coast. Unusually for a New Zealand network, they connect real places rather than just scenic loops — you can commute, shop and get to a cellar door on them.

Combined with the climate, that makes this one of the few New Zealand regions where cycling to work year-round is comfortable. A good number of clinicians here do exactly that, and it is a strong argument for living in Taradale, Havelock North or central Hastings.

Distances worth knowing

Times on a good run. Add for the Taupō road in winter and for the northern route in poor weather.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).



08

THE BEST TABLE IN THE COUNTRY

Food, wine & the everyday

If you care about food, this is the chapter that will decide it. Hawke's Bay has the strongest food and wine culture of any region in this collection, and it is not a tourism claim — it is the everyday consequence of hot summers, good soil and a hundred and fifty years of growing things.

HAVELOCK NORTH

The best concentration in the region — village cafés, bakeries and a couple of genuinely serious restaurants, with Te Mata Peak behind.

AHURIRI & NAPIER

The waterfront and the Art Deco streets. Good restaurants, wine bars and a strong café scene, busier in summer.

HASTINGS

More mixed and more everyday, with excellent Asian and Pacific food reflecting the city's population, and a redeveloping centre.

The wine

Hawke's Bay is New Zealand's oldest wine region and, for reds, its best. The **Gimblett Gravels** — a defined stretch of old riverbed near Hastings — produce syrah and Bordeaux-style blends that stand comparison with anywhere. The region's chardonnay is widely held to be the country's finest.

What matters day to day is that the cellar doors are twenty minutes from your house, most of them are free or nearly so to visit, and the wine costs less here than in a Wellington shop. Sunday lunch at a vineyard stops being an occasion and becomes a habit.

The food

This is the fruit bowl of New Zealand: apples, pears, stone fruit, berries and squash off the Heretaunga plain, sold at orchard gates and roadside stalls through the season. Olive oil, cheese, cider and honey are all made locally and well.

Groceries and the practical stuff

All the main supermarket chains, in both cities, plus large-format retail. Food in New Zealand is expensive by British or Australian standards — national rather than regional — but the fresh produce here is the exception, and it is a real one.

For specialist ingredients: there are Asian, Indian and Pacific grocers across both cities, a good range of halal options, and specialist butchers and delis. It is not Auckland. If a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, check before committing — the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.



09

WEEKENDS HERE

Beaches, Te Mata Peak & wine country

A flat plain with two hundred kilometres of cycle trail on it, a peak with the region's best view above it, surf beaches half an hour east, and hill country and ranges behind. Most of it is free and almost all of it is close.

WAIMARAMA & OCEAN BEACH

Thirty to forty minutes south-east over the hills. Proper surf beaches, patrolled in summer, and the region's weekend default.

TE AWANGA & HAUMOANA

Twenty-five minutes from Napier, where the vineyards meet the shingle beach. Cellar doors and sea in the same afternoon.

CAPE KIDNAPPERS

One of the world's most accessible mainland gannet colonies, on the cliffs at the end of the bay. Reachable on foot at low tide or by tour.

Te Mata Peak

The landmark, and the region's daily ritual. A steep ridge rising straight off the plain behind Havelock North, with a road to the top and a network of tracks up it. From the summit you get the whole bay, the plain, the ranges and, on a clear day, Ruapehu.

It takes about forty minutes to walk up and it is busy at dawn and dusk with people doing exactly that before or after work. Te Mata is also a place of significance in local tradition, and the story of the sleeping giant is worth knowing before you climb it.

The coast

Flat, sealed and linked, the network runs along the rivers, around the coast and between the cellar doors. It earns its Great Ride status by being useful: the same paths carry a family Sunday, a wine loop and a commute.

The rides themselves are below – the Wineries loop is the one to do first.

On two wheels

The **Hawke's Bay Trails** deserve their own paragraph. Around two hundred kilometres of linked, sealed, flat path across the plain, along the Tukituki and Ngāruroro rivers and around the coast – one of New Zealand's Great Rides, and unusually useful because it connects real destinations.

The Wineries Ride is the one people do first: a flat loop between cellar doors with a designated driver or a shuttle at the end. The Landscapes and Water Rides cover the coast and the rivers. Bike hire is easy and the whole network is genuinely family-friendly.

Useful links

The region's official visitor site: the trails, the cellar doors, events and what's on.

COUNCIL

Napier City Council ↗

Local services, libraries, pools and parks on the Napier side.

COUNCIL

Hastings District Council ↗

Services, schools information and community life around the hospital.

OUTDOORS

Department of Conservation ↗

Tracks, huts and reserves across the Kaweka and Ruahine ranges and the coast.

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Hawke's Bay. Everything national — visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori — lives in [Moving to New Zealand](#). When you'd like to talk it through, [we're here](#), with no pressure and no pipeline.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Hawke's Bay is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Hawke's Bay guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/hawkes-bay-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
